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ANTHROPOLOGY OF COMMUNICATION

How Culture Shapes the Way We Speak

What Was Said vs. What Was Meant

01 The Words We Choose, The Meaning We Hide

- High-context cultures hide meaning in tone, relationship and situation; low-context cultures say it directly (Edward T. Hall).
- Polite indirectness protects “face”: “We’ll see” or “Dekhte hain” can quietly mean no.
- Idioms, proverbs and honorifics carry values that never translate word for word.

02 Gestures, Glances & Personal Space

- Proxemics: every culture has its own comfortable distance for intimate, personal, social and public talk.
- Eye contact signals respect in one culture and challenge or rudeness in another.
- The same gesture, such as a thumbs-up or a head nod, can carry opposite meanings across borders.

03 The Power of Silence

- Silence can mean respect, agreement, disagreement, thought or deep discomfort.
- Japanese ma and Western Apache silence (Keith Basso) treat pauses as meaningful, not empty.
- Where talk is valued, silence feels awkward; where listening is valued, interrupting it feels rude.

04 The Cost of Misleading Cultural Communication

- Lost deals, failed negotiations and workplace conflict grow from misread signals.
- Misunderstandings in healthcare, education and diplomacy can harm real people.
- Judging others by our own norms is ethnocentrism; the cure is curiosity, observation and clarifying questions.

Communication is not only what we say; it is what our culture taught us to mean.

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